
Cold-Weather Stiffness

Why winter actually hurts more — and what to do
about it without moving to Florida

NATE RATCLIFF, LMT

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HEALING HANDS BY NATE

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Introduction

A BETWEEN-SESSIONS MODULE ON THE BIOLOGY of winter pain and the small daily moves that keep you mobile through it.

You're not imagining it. You really do hurt more in November. Here's the biology behind it and what you can actually do about it without moving to Florida.

I get a wave of new and returning clients every November. People who were fine in September. People who pushed through October. People who finally surrender to the table because their low back hurts when they get out of bed, their hands feel locked in the morning, and they can't figure out why everything is suddenly worse.

The answer is biology. Cold genuinely makes your body stiffer, slower, and more pain-prone. It's not "old age." It's not weakness. It's a temperature-mediated change in your tissue, your blood flow, and your nervous system that happens every winter to every human body.

The good news: it's predictable, and it responds to a few specific daily moves. You don't have to spend four months stiff.

CHAPTER 1

Why cold makes everything worse

THREE THINGS HAPPEN TO YOUR BODY WHEN THE temperature drops, and they all stack:

1. Blood flow to muscles decreases

Your body's job in cold weather is to keep your core organs warm. To do that, it constricts blood vessels in your skin and surface muscles, sending the warm blood deeper inward.

This is great for keeping you alive. It's bad for your muscles. Less blood flow means:

- Less oxygen reaching the tissue
- Less nutrient delivery
- Slower waste removal
- Reduced muscle warmth

A muscle with reduced blood flow is a stiffer, slower, less-responsive muscle. It's also more vulnerable to strain because it doesn't move through its full range as easily.

2. Connective tissue becomes less pliable

Fascia, ligaments, tendons — all the connective tissue in your body — gets stiffer in cold. Think of it like leaving a rubber band in the freezer. It still works, but it doesn't stretch the way it does at room temperature.

This is why the same range of motion that's comfortable in July feels restricted in January. Your tissue is literally less elastic. Pushing into a stretch the way you would in summer can cause micro-tears in winter tissue.

3. The nervous system tightens its tolerance window

In cold, your nervous system becomes more protective. The threshold for "this feels like too much" drops. Sensations that wouldn't register as pain in summer become uncomfortable. Stretches that feel productive in summer feel sharp in winter.

This is biological, not psychological. Your nervous system is genuinely more reactive when peripheral tissue is cold and blood flow is restricted.

All three things stack. By the time you actually try to move in the morning, you're working with stiffer tissue, less blood flow, and a more reactive nervous system. Of course it hurts more.

CHAPTER 2

Why mornings are the worst

MORNING STIFFNESS IN WINTER IS WORSE FOR A specific reason: your body cooled down significantly overnight. You've been lying still for 7-8 hours, in a cool bedroom, with reduced movement keeping tissue warm.

The first 10 minutes of your day in winter are the highest-risk window for tweaking something. The tissue is at its coldest. The blood flow is at its lowest. The nervous system is at its most reactive.

Most cold-weather injuries I see happen in this window — bending down to put on socks and tweaking a back. Reaching to start the coffee and pulling a shoulder. Walking to the bathroom and turning a stiff ankle on nothing in particular.

These aren't random injuries. They're predictable consequences of asking cold tissue to perform without warm-up.

CHAPTER 3

What actually helps

THREE CATEGORIES OF INTERVENTION, IN ORDER of importance.

1. The first-10-minutes-of-the-day protocol

Before you do anything strenuous, you need to warm the tissue up. This is non-negotiable in winter.

Option A — In-bed warmup (for the most cautious approach):

Before you even sit up, do this lying down:

- Ankle circles, both feet, 10 each direction
- Knees to chest, both at once, gentle rocking, 30 seconds
- Spinal twist on back, knees to one side, 30 seconds each side
- Arms overhead stretch, 15 seconds
- Slow neck rotations after you sit up, 5 each direction

Takes 3-4 minutes. Adds blood flow to all major joints before you stand.

Option B — First-thing-after-getting-up routine:

- 20 marching steps in place (knees up, slow)
- 10 arm circles each direction
- 10 slow shoulder shrugs
- 10 slow squats (don't go deep, just shallow knee bends to warm the joints)
- Standing forward fold, hang for 30 seconds

Takes 4-5 minutes. Wakes everything up.

Pick one. Do it every morning. The 4-5 minutes you invest here saves you from the tweaks and pulls that derail winter weeks.

2. Hot shower protocol

This is the move most people don't think to use deliberately.

Before your day starts — especially before any physical work or activity — let your shower water run hot on the joints and muscles most likely to give you problems.

For most people:

- Back of the neck and shoulders, 2-3 minutes
- Lower back, 2-3 minutes
- Any specific area that's been talking to you lately, 1-2 minutes

Hot water increases surface blood flow rapidly. It warms the tissue. It signals your nervous system to relax bracing patterns. By the time you step out, your tissue is significantly more pliable than when you stepped in.

This works even better if you can do gentle range-of-motion movements while the hot water is on the area — slow shoulder rolls under the hot stream, gentle low-back arching, neck rotations. Combine the heat with the movement.

For people who don't shower in the morning, a hot water bottle, microwaved rice sock, or heated blanket on those areas for 10-15 minutes accomplishes most of the same thing.

3. Warm up twice as long before any activity

In summer, you can get away with 5 minutes of warm-up before any physical task. In winter, that doubles. Plan for 8-10 minutes of warm-up before:

- Going outside to shovel anything
- Hauling firewood
- Carrying groceries up icy steps
- Hunting (yes, you've been sitting in the cold — that's not a warm-up)
- Any strenuous yard work
- Working out

This feels like overkill the first few times. Then you'll tweak something doing yard work in 25-degree weather without warming up enough, and you'll understand why I keep saying it.

The warm-up doesn't have to be elaborate — just intentional movement that gets blood flowing to the muscles you're about to use. Walking briskly for 5 minutes works. Arm circles + leg swings + torso twists for 5 minutes works. The goal is just to get the body warm before you ask it to perform.

CHAPTER 4

The minimum effective dose of winter movement

MOST PEOPLE MOVE SIGNIFICANTLY LESS IN winter. Days are short. It's cold outside. The motivation isn't there. The cumulative effect is months of decreased movement that compounds the stiffness biology.

The minimum effective dose to prevent winter from wrecking you:

- **10 minutes of stretching per day, every day, no exceptions** — your morning routine OR the 15-min mid-back open-up from Month 8 OR the 5-minute morning unlock + 5 more minutes of your choice
- **30 minutes of walking, 4-5 days a week** — yes, in the cold. Bundle up. Doesn't have to be brisk.
- **One bodywork session per month if you can swing it** — keeps the cumulative tightness from setting in

If you do nothing else, the daily 10-minute stretch alone keeps you mobile through winter. Skip it and the spring recovery is brutal.

CHAPTER 5

When to come see me

IF YOU'RE ALREADY ENTERING WINTER WITH significant tightness from the summer-fall season (and you're a current client, you know who you are), book a session in November before it sets in. December and January, the cumulative cold-induced tightness layers on top of whatever was already there, and the work gets harder.

The bodies that come in for their first session in March after a hard winter are taking 2-3 months to undo what 6 weeks of pre-winter and mid-winter sessions would have prevented.

I'd rather see you in November and not in March than the other way around.

CHAPTER 6

What if you have arthritis or joint pain that flares in cold?

MANY OLDER CLIENTS HAVE SPECIFIC JOINTS that flare in cold weather — old knee injuries, arthritic hips, hands that throb. The same protocols help, but you may also benefit from:

- Heat on the affected joint(s) twice daily, not just morning
- Slightly increased dose of fish oil or omega-3 supplements (talk to your doctor)
- Compression sleeves on flaring joints during the day
- Specific massage on the affected area — call to book if you have a regular flare pattern, we'll work it

The cold-flare pattern is real and well-documented. You're not making it up. There are real interventions that help.

CHAPTER 7

Closing

WINTER DOESN'T HAVE TO MEAN FOUR MONTHS of stiffness. Move in the morning, warm up before you work, stretch before bed. Your body will stay with you.

The biology of cold is real and predictable. So is the protocol that addresses it. None of this is dramatic — small daily moves, done consistently, that keep blood flowing to tissue that wants to slow down in winter.

Start tomorrow morning. Pick the in-bed warmup or the get-up routine. Do it before your feet hit the floor. Set the tone for the day.

Your spring self will thank you for what your winter self does or doesn't do over the next four months.

The companion workbook has a winter readiness self-check, a 7-day morning warm-up tracker, and three reflection prompts to help you notice your own cold-weather patterns.

— Nate



This book was crafted by Nate Ratcliff,
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